▼ MITALI BAG, *47*

| TMC | *Arambagh (SC), West Bengal*



The last TMC MP here, Aparupa Poddar, had gotten into a bit of a tangle on the question of whether she had turned into Afrin Ali (after marrying a Muslim), and whether that disqualified her from this SC reserved seat. Anyway, in came an unmarried unknown—a mofussil Mamata, so to speak. An anganwadi worker in 2010, her diligence as a zilla parishad member had caught the scouting eye of I-PAC surveyors. The poorest among the new LS MPs, with just Rs 7.8 lakh to her name, she finally wrested a seat even the TMC leadership thought would go to the BJP.

▼ HAJI HANIFA JAN, *55*

| INDEPENDENT | *Ladakh*



One figure emerged from the fog of factionalism. The INDIA bloc missed a trick, and his name was Haji. The National Conference district chief, a former chief executive councillor of the Kargil section of Ladakh Autonomous Hill Development Council, was his party's original choice. But it went along with the Congress's choice from Leh: Tsering Namgyal. When Haji went renegade, the whole Kargil unit of the NC resigned en masse in support. That he also got bipartisan support from Buddhist Leh showed how angry and united Ladakh was on its key demands: statehood, Sixth Schedule protection and two Lok Sabha seats. That the BJP came third was proof.



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

◀ BHARTI PARDHI, *54*

| BJP | *Balaghat, MP*

Her grandfather-in-law, Bholaram Pardhi, represented Balaghat in the 1960s but she was a fresh arrival in the major league. The highest she had risen till she was picked for the Lok Sabha contest ahead of sitting MP Dhal Singh Bisen was the post she held, that of local corporator. But she was from the Panwar community, influential in this part of Mahakoshal, and the party had held this Narmada-fed constituency since 1998. Affable, and graceful in victory, her first visit was to the house of Ashok Saraswar of the Congress, whom she'd defeated by 174,512 votes.



ALOK SHARMA, *56*

| BJP | *Bhopal, MP*

A Bhopali from the Old City, whose recent passion has been to obliterate its nawabi past—nomenclaturally. For all his saffron upbringing—ABVP, BJP youth wing—and perceived proximity to Shivraj Singh Chouhan, corporator and mayor is all Sharma managed, losing assembly polls twice from Bhopal North—in 2008 and in 2023. But his lifelong zeal was rewarded with one of the safest seats for the BJP in the country.



CHANDU SHIHORA, *62*

| BJP | *Surendranagar, Gujarat*

Farmer by profession, civil engineer by education, ex-president of the Morbi district panchayat, partyman for decades, and a community leader among the 'most backward' Chuvaliya Kolis—so went a hinterland resume with as much promise as any other in the BJP. But the Kshatriya protests had intensified around this seat, so it was marked as a 'tight contest'. Moreover, a rival Koli subcaste had wanted their man in, so were upset. But his philanthropism, especially the mass weddings he organised, ensured another handsome debut.



HARIBHAI PATEL, *63*

| BJP | *Mehsana, Gujarat*

Once a teacher of fine arts, now running a business, his political apex till now had been a modest one: president of the standing committee of the district panchayat. But his 30-year party association and roots in the influential Kadva Patidar community sufficed to secure him a comfortable margin of 320,000 votes.